BIPHMUN 2026

Background Guide

Committee: Historical Human Rights Council

Topic: Protecting Civilian Populations under the Cyprus Crisis (1963-1974)

Agenda Overseen by: Daniel Wang

1. Description of the Issue

1.1 History of the Issue

The Cyprus Crisis (1963–1974) was a violent conflict between Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot communities on the island of Cyprus. It involved civil conflict, foreign intervention, and widespread civilian suffering. The crisis caused thousands of deaths, large population displacement, and the long-term division of the island. The conflict also became an international issue because several countries—especially Greece, Turkey, and the United Kingdom—had legal and political interests in Cyprus. The United Nations eventually deployed peacekeepers to prevent further violence. Even today, Cyprus remains divided along the same lines created during this crisis.

1.1.1 Background before 1963

Cyprus had been under British colonial rule since 1878. The island had two main ethnic communities. About 80 percent of the population was Greek Cypriot, and about 18 percent was Turkish Cypriot. Many Greek Cypriots supported enosis, the idea that Cyprus should unite with Greece. In contrast, many Turkish Cypriots supported taksim, the idea of dividing the island between Greek and Turkish areas (Oberling).

Violence between the communities increased during the 1950s. The Greek Cyprimilitant group EOKA launched an armed campaign against British rule in 1955. Although the main target was the colonial government, violence also increased between Greek and Turkish communities (Ker-Lindsay).

After years of conflict, Cyprus became an independent republic in 1960. The independence agreement created a power-sharing government between Greek Cypriots and Turkish Cypriots. The constitution gave both communities political protections. For example, the Turkish Cypriot vice president had veto power over certain decisions, and government positions were divided between the two groups (Ker-Lindsay).

At the same time, the Treaty of Guarantee was signed by Greece, Turkey, and the United Kingdom. The treaty allowed these countries to intervene if the constitutional order in Cyprus was threatened. The goal was to maintain independence and protect both communities (United Nations).

However, the constitutional system quickly faced problems. Greek Cypriot leaders argued that the government structure made decision-making difficult. Turkish Cypriots feared that any changes would weaken their security and political rights. Tension grew throughout the early 1960s.

1.1.2 Outbreak of Violence in 1963

The crisis began in December 1963. President Archbishop Makarios proposed thirteen amendments to the constitution. These changes would reduce Turkish Cypriot political powers. Turkish Cypriot leaders rejected the proposals because they believed the changes would allow Greek Cypriots to dominate the government (Ker-Lindsay).

Soon afterward, violence broke out between the two communities. On 21 December 1963, a confrontation between police and Turkish Cypriot civilians in Nicosia escalated into armed conflict. The fighting quickly spread across the island. This event became known as "Bloody Christmas." In the following months, intercommunal violence killed hundreds of people (Pierre Oberling 120; United Nations).

During this period, 364 Turkish Cypriots and 174 Greek Cypriots were killed. Thousands of homes were destroyed. About 25,000 Turkish Cypriots were forced to leave their homes and move into isolated enclaves for safety (International Center for Transitional Justice). Living conditions in these enclaves were extremely poor. Many families lived in tents or temporary shelters.

Violence continued throughout 1964. Armed groups on both sides carried out attacks on villages and neighborhoods. For example, clashes in the town of Famagusta in May 1964 led to the killing of Turkish Cypriot civilians (Oberling; United Nations). At the same time, Greek Cypriot communities also experienced attacks and insecurity.

The conflict soon threatened international stability. Greece and Turkey both supported their ethnic communities on the island. Military confrontation between the two NATO members became a serious possibility.

1.1.3 United Nations Intervention

Because the violence continued, the United Nations intervened. In March 1964, the UN Security Council passed Resolution 186, which created the United Nations Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus (UNFICYP). The mission's goal was to prevent further fighting, restore law and order, and help return the island to normal conditions (United Nations Peacekeeping).

UN peacekeepers established patrols and observation posts across the island. They also helped negotiate local ceasefires between armed groups. In addition, the mission delivered humanitarian assistance to civilians affected by violence.

Despite these efforts, the conflict did not end. The island slowly became divided into Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot areas. A ceasefire line called the Green Line separated communities in the capital city of Nicosia.

1.1.4 Continuing Conflict (1964–1974)

From 1964 to 1974, Cyprus remained unstable. Although large-scale fighting decreased after 1964, smaller clashes continued. Turkish Cypriots remained confined to enclaves in many areas. At the same time, both Greece and Turkey continued to influence events on the island.

The crisis worsened in the early 1970s. Greek nationalist groups again pushed for enosis with Greece. In July 1974, a military coup was carried out by the Cypriot National Guard with support from the Greek military government. The coup removed

President Makarios and replaced him with a leader who supported union with Greece ("Events in the Summer of 1974").

Turkey responded quickly. On 20 July 1974, Turkish forces launched a military intervention in northern Cyprus. Turkey argued that the intervention was legal under the Treaty of Guarantee and was necessary to protect Turkish Cypriots. Turkish troops landed near the city of Kyrenia and advanced inland ("Events in the Summer of 1974").

Heavy fighting followed. Battles occurred across northern Cyprus, including near the capital city of Nicosia. Civilians on both sides suffered greatly. Many people fled their homes to escape the violence.

By August 1974, Turkish forces controlled about 37 percent of the island. A ceasefire line divided Cyprus into two separate zones. The northern area was controlled by Turkish Cypriots and supported by Turkey, while the southern area remained under the control of the Republic of Cyprus (United Nations Peacekeeping).

1.1.5 Humanitarian Consequences

The Cyprus Crisis had major consequences for civilian populations. Large numbers of people were displaced during the conflict. Approximately 160,000 Greek Cypriots fled from northern areas after the Turkish intervention, while about 45,000 Turkish Cypriots moved to the north.

Many families lost homes, land, and property. Others were separated from relatives who remained on the other side of the dividing line. Some civilians also disappeared during the conflict, and their fate remains unknown.

The conflict also created a permanent military buffer zone across the island. This area is still monitored by UN peacekeepers today.

1.1.6 International Significance

The Cyprus Crisis was significant for several reasons. First, it involved conflict between two NATO members—Greece and Turkey—which raised fears of a larger war during the Cold War. Second, it became one of the longest-running peacekeeping missions in United Nations history. UNFICYP has remained in Cyprus since 1964.

Finally, the crisis showed how ethnic conflict can lead to long-term political division. Even today, Cyprus remains split between north and south. The issues of civilian protection, displaced populations, and political sovereignty remain unresolved.

For the international community, the Cyprus Crisis remains an important case study in peacekeeping, conflict mediation, and civilian protection during internal conflicts.

1.2 Definition of Key Terms

1.2.1. Cyprus Crisis (1963–1974)

A period of intercommunal violence and international conflict in Cyprus involving Greek Cypriots, Turkish Cypriots, Greece, Turkey, and the United Nations.

1.2.2. Greek Cypriots

The majority ethnic group in Cyprus. Most Greek Cypriots share Greek cultural identity and historically supported union with Greece.

1.2.3. Turkish Cypriots

The main ethnic minority group in Cyprus. Turkish Cypriots have cultural and political ties to Turkey.

1.2.4. Enosis

A political movement that supported the union of Cyprus with Greece.

1.2.5. Taksim

A political concept that proposed dividing Cyprus into separate Greek and Turkish regions.

1.2.6. United Nations Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus (UNFICYP)

A UN peacekeeping mission established in 1964 to prevent further fighting and maintain stability on the island.

1.2.7. Green Line

The ceasefire line dividing Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot areas in Cyprus, especially in the capital city of Nicosia.

1.2.8. Treaty of Guarantee (1960)

An international agreement signed by Cyprus, Greece, Turkey, and the United Kingdom. It allowed these countries to intervene to protect Cyprus's independence and constitutional order.

1.2.9. Intercommunal Violence

Violent conflict between different ethnic or communal groups within the same country.

1.2.10. Displaced Persons

Civilians forced to leave their homes because of war, violence, or political instability.

1.2.11. Enclaves

Small areas where a minority population is surrounded by territory controlled by another group.

1.2.12. Buffer Zone

A demilitarized area monitored by peacekeepers to separate opposing forces and prevent further fighting.

1.3 Past International Actions

The Cyprus Crisis quickly attracted international attention because it threatened regional stability. Several international actors attempted to stop the violence and protect civilian populations. These efforts included diplomatic negotiations, peacekeeping operations, and humanitarian assistance. However, most attempts achieved only partial success.

1.3.1 United Nations Peacekeeping Mission

The most significant international action was the creation of the United Nations Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus (UNFICYP) in 1964. The UN Security Council established the mission through Resolution 186 after intercommunal violence threatened to escalate further (United Nations Peacekeeping).

UNFICYP had three main goals:

1. Prevent further fighting between Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot forces;
2. Maintain law and order across the island;
3. Help restore normal living conditions for civilians.

At its peak in 1964, the mission included more than 6,000 military personnel from several countries. Peacekeepers established observation posts, conducted patrols, and separated armed groups in conflict areas.

The mission successfully reduced large-scale violence. Peacekeepers helped maintain ceasefires and prevented many local conflicts from escalating. They also provided humanitarian assistance to displaced civilians.

However, UNFICYP had important limitations. The mission could monitor and report violence, but it could not impose a political settlement. The UN also lacked the authority to disarm militias or force political compromises between the two communities.

As a result, while UNFICYP stabilized the situation temporarily, it did not resolve the underlying conflict.

1.3.2 Diplomatic Negotiations

Several diplomatic efforts attempted to reach a political solution. Negotiations were often organized by the United Nations or by the guarantor powers—Greece, Turkey, and the United Kingdom.

One important diplomatic initiative occurred during the Geneva Conference of 1974. After the Turkish intervention began, representatives from Greece, Turkey, and the United Kingdom met in Geneva to negotiate a ceasefire and political settlement.

These talks produced temporary agreements to stop fighting. However, negotiations failed to reach a long-term solution. Military operations resumed shortly afterward.

1.3.3 Security Council Resolutions

The United Nations Security Council also adopted several resolutions addressing the conflict. For example, Resolution 353 (1974) called for an immediate ceasefire and demanded an end to foreign military intervention in Cyprus ("Events in the Summer of 1974").

The resolution also encouraged negotiations between Greece, Turkey, and the United Kingdom to restore peace and constitutional government in Cyprus.

Although these resolutions helped create ceasefire conditions, they were not fully enforced. Fighting continued during the summer of 1974 until the island was effectively divided.

1.3.4 Humanitarian Assistance

International organizations also attempted to reduce civilian suffering. UN peacekeepers helped deliver food, medical supplies, and shelter to displaced populations. They also assisted in evacuating civilians from combat areas.

Humanitarian assistance saved many lives. However, these efforts could not reverse the massive population displacement caused by the conflict.

1.3.5 Evaluation of International Actions

Overall, international actions during the Cyprus Crisis had mixed results. On one hand, UN peacekeeping successfully prevented the conflict from escalating into a larger war between Greece and Turkey. The presence of international forces also reduced civilian casualties after the initial outbreak of violence. On the other hand, international efforts failed to resolve the political causes of the conflict. Cyprus remained divided after 1974, and negotiations for reunification have continued for decades without a final agreement. The Cyprus Crisis therefore demonstrates both the strengths and limitations of international intervention. Peacekeeping operations can stabilize a conflict and protect civilians. However, without political compromise between the parties involved, long-term peace remains difficult to achieve.

2. Bloc Positions

2.1 Western NATO Powers

These countries were generally aligned with the Western bloc during the Cold War and shared an interest in maintaining stability within the NATO alliance. In the Cyprus Crisis, they focused on preventing war between Greece and Turkey, supporting United Nations peacekeeping, and protecting strategic interests in the Eastern Mediterranean.

2.1.1 Greece

Greece played a central role in the Cyprus Crisis because of its political, cultural, and strategic ties to Greek Cypriots. Many Greek Cypriots historically supported enosis, or union with Greece. During the early 1960s, the Greek government publicly supported the independence of Cyprus but also sought to protect Greek Cypriot political interests (Ker-Lindsay 45).

Greek policy became more aggressive in the early 1970s. The military government ruling Greece at the time supported Greek nationalist groups in Cyprus that promoted enosis. In July 1974, elements of the Cypriot National Guard, backed by the Greek junta, carried out a coup that removed President Makarios and installed a pro-Greek government (Mallinson 127). Greece argued that its actions were intended to secure the political rights of Greek Cypriots. However, the coup triggered a major escalation. Turkey responded with a military intervention on the island. This led to large-scale fighting and massive civilian displacement. Overall, Greece emphasized the protection of Greek Cypriot interests but faced international criticism for contributing to the escalation of the conflict.

2.1.2 Turkey

Turkey viewed the Cyprus Crisis primarily as an issue of security and minority protection. Turkish leaders argued that Turkish Cypriots faced discrimination and violence after the breakdown of the 1960 constitutional system (Oberling 132).

Turkey was also a guarantor power under the Treaty of Guarantee. Turkish officials argued that this treaty allowed intervention if the constitutional order in Cyprus collapsed. When violence against Turkish Cypriots increased in the 1960s, Turkey repeatedly warned that it might intervene militarily to protect the community (Ker-Lindsay 53).

After the 1974 coup supported by the Greek military government, Turkey launched a military operation on 20 July 1974. Turkish leaders argued that the intervention was necessary to restore constitutional order and protect Turkish Cypriots from further attacks (Mallinson 140). However, the military operation resulted in the occupation of northern Cyprus and the displacement of large numbers of civilians. The intervention remains one of the most controversial aspects of the Cyprus Crisis.

2.1.3 United States

The United States viewed the Cyprus Crisis primarily through the lens of Cold War strategy. Greece and Turkey were both members of NATO. Any war between them would weaken the alliance and create opportunities for Soviet influence in the Mediterranean (Mallinson 88).

Because of this concern, the United States focused on preventing escalation rather than supporting one side directly. Washington pressured both Greece and Turkey to avoid military confrontation. For example, in 1964 U.S. President Lyndon Johnson sent a letter warning Turkey not to launch a large-scale invasion of Cyprus (Johnson).

At the same time, the United States supported United Nations peacekeeping efforts. American diplomacy encouraged negotiations between the parties and supported the deployment of UNFICYP. However, critics argue that U.S. policy focused more on NATO stability than on protecting civilians on the island (O'Malley and Craig 137).

Overall, the United States promoted mediation and restraint. Its main priority was preventing a wider war.

2.1.4 United Kingdom

The United Kingdom had one of the most direct roles in the Cyprus Crisis. Cyprus had been a British colony until 1960. Even after independence, the United Kingdom kept two sovereign military bases on the island: Akrotiri and Dhekelia (Ker-Lindsay 32).

Britain was also one of the three guarantor powers under the Treaty of Guarantee. This gave the United Kingdom legal responsibility to protect Cyprus's independence and constitutional order.

During the violence of 1963–1964, British troops initially helped separate Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot forces. British officers also drew the first version of the Green Line in Nicosia to stop fighting between the communities (Ker-Lindsay 37).

Later, Britain strongly supported the establishment of UNFICYP. British soldiers formed a large part of the early peacekeeping force. The United Kingdom preferred international peacekeeping rather than unilateral military intervention. This approach helped reduce tensions between Greece and Turkey.

Britain therefore focused on stabilization, ceasefire monitoring, and protecting strategic military interests.

2.1.5 France

France supported diplomatic solutions and United Nations involvement. As a permanent member of the UN Security Council, France voted in favor of resolutions establishing peacekeeping operations in Cyprus.

French policy emphasized respect for national sovereignty and international law. France generally supported negotiations between Greece, Turkey, and Cyprus rather than direct intervention. France also contributed to broader international discussions about peacekeeping and civilian protection during the Cold War period. Its position was largely supportive of UN mediation efforts (United Nations Security Council).

2.1.6 Canada

Canada played an important role in peacekeeping operations in Cyprus. Canadian forces were among the first contributors to UNFICYP in 1964. At one point, Canada provided more than 1,000 soldiers to the mission (Government of Canada).

Canadian peacekeepers patrolled the buffer zone, monitored ceasefires, and protected civilian populations in areas of tension. Canadian diplomacy also supported negotiated political solutions through the United Nations. Canada's role in Cyprus became one of the longest peacekeeping deployments in its history. The country maintained troops on the island for nearly three decades. This position reflected Canada's broader foreign policy. During the Cold War, Canada strongly supported multilateral peacekeeping as a method for preventing international conflicts.

2.1.7 Japan

Japan had a limited direct role in the Cyprus Crisis. However, as a major economic power and UN member, Japan supported peacekeeping and diplomatic solutions. Japan consistently supported UN resolutions calling for ceasefires and negotiations. Japanese foreign policy after World War II emphasized peaceful conflict resolution and support for international institutions (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan). Japan

therefore aligned itself with broader international efforts to stabilize the conflict and protect civilians.

2.2 Eastern Bloc

These states were politically aligned with the Soviet Union and often criticized Western military influence in regional conflicts. In the Cyprus Crisis, they emphasized the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Cyprus while supporting diplomatic solutions through the United Nations.

2.2.1 Soviet Union

The Soviet Union strongly supported the independence and territorial integrity of Cyprus. Moscow opposed foreign military intervention on the island, particularly by NATO members.

Soviet leaders criticized the possibility of Turkish invasion during the 1960s and warned that military intervention could destabilize the region. The Soviet Union also supported the Cypriot government led by President Makarios (Mallinson 110). From a strategic perspective, the Soviet Union saw the Cyprus Crisis as an opportunity to weaken NATO unity. A conflict between Greece and Turkey could divide the Western alliance. However, the Soviet Union also publicly supported diplomatic negotiations and United Nations peacekeeping. Soviet representatives voted in favor of several UN resolutions related to Cyprus.

Thus, the Soviet position combined geopolitical interests with formal support for international mediation.

2.2.2 German Democratic Republic

The German Democratic Republic generally followed the foreign policy line of the Soviet Union during the Cold War. East Germany viewed the Cyprus Crisis largely through the broader competition between NATO and the socialist bloc. Its government criticized Western influence in the Eastern Mediterranean and supported the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Cyprus (Westad 206).

East German diplomacy supported United Nations involvement and negotiations between the parties. At the same time, it argued that external pressure from NATO members contributed to instability on the island (Mallinson 118). Like other Eastern Bloc states, East Germany emphasized political independence for Cyprus and opposed foreign intervention that might undermine the authority of the Cypriot government (Ker-Lindsay 64).

2.2.3 Czechoslovakia

Czechoslovakia aligned closely with Soviet foreign policy during this period. It supported Cyprus's independence and criticized Western influence in the region. Czechoslovakia supported UN peacekeeping operations but also emphasized the need to limit NATO involvement in Cyprus. The country's position reflected the broader policies of the Eastern Bloc during the Cold War.

2.3 Non-Aligned States

These countries were not formally aligned with either the Western or Eastern blocs during the Cold War. Their policies generally emphasized national sovereignty, non-intervention, and peaceful conflict resolution through international mediation and United Nations diplomacy.

2.3.1 China

During the 1960s and early 1970s, the People's Republic of China emphasized principles of sovereignty and opposition to foreign intervention.

China criticized external interference in Cyprus and supported the independence of smaller states. Chinese diplomats argued that the Cypriot people should determine their own political future without outside pressure. China also expressed support for negotiations and peaceful conflict resolution within the framework of the United Nations (United Nations General Assembly). At the time, China was expanding its influence in international diplomacy. Supporting anti-colonial positions helped strengthen China's relationships with developing countries.

2.3.1 India

India strongly supported Cyprus's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Indian leaders viewed the conflict partly as a legacy of colonial rule and ethnic division.

India also had a strong tradition of supporting United Nations peacekeeping operations. Indian diplomats frequently advocated for diplomatic solutions and non-aligned mediation. Although India did not deploy large military forces to Cyprus, it supported UN resolutions and encouraged peaceful negotiations between Greece, Turkey, and Cyprus (Ministry of External Affairs of India). India's position reflected the broader principles of the Non-Aligned Movement. These included respect for national sovereignty and peaceful conflict resolution.

2.3.1 Yugoslavia

Yugoslavia also supported Cyprus through the Non-Aligned Movement. President Josip Broz Tito maintained close political ties with President Makarios.

Yugoslavia emphasized the importance of national independence and opposed external military intervention. Yugoslav diplomacy supported negotiations and international mediation. At the same time, Yugoslavia promoted cooperation among developing countries and encouraged diplomatic solutions through international institutions (Westad).

3. Possible Solutions

3.1 Strengthening the UN Peacekeeping Mandate

Delegates may propose expanding the authority of the United Nations Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus (UNFICYP). During the early years of the crisis, peacekeepers could monitor violence but had limited authority to intervene directly (United Nations Peacekeeping). A stronger mandate could allow peacekeepers to patrol high-risk areas more frequently, escort civilians during evacuations, and respond quickly to outbreaks

of violence. Additional personnel and equipment could improve monitoring of conflict zones. Delegates could also propose clearer coordination between UN forces and local authorities. This would help prevent misunderstandings and reduce the risk of accidental clashes. Strengthening peacekeeping operations could provide immediate protection for civilians while longer-term political negotiations continue.

3.2 Establishing Civilian Protection Zones

Delegates may propose internationally supervised protection zones for civilians. These zones would provide temporary safety for civilians during periods of intense violence. Protection zones could be monitored by UN peacekeepers and humanitarian organizations. Weapons would be prohibited inside these areas. Civilians from both communities could seek shelter without fear of attack. These zones would not permanently divide territory. Instead, they would provide emergency protection while diplomatic negotiations continue. Clear rules and international monitoring would be necessary to maintain neutrality and prevent armed groups from using these areas for military purposes.

3.3 Creating Humanitarian Access Corridors

Another practical solution is the establishment of humanitarian corridors. These routes would allow safe delivery of food, medicine, and relief supplies to displaced populations. Humanitarian corridors could be negotiated between the conflicting parties and supervised by UN observers. Peacekeepers could escort aid convoys to reduce the risk of attacks. Such corridors would also allow civilians to leave active combat zones safely. In many conflicts, lack of safe passage significantly increases civilian casualties (United Nations). Providing secure access for humanitarian organizations would reduce suffering among displaced communities and improve living conditions in refugee areas.

3.4 International Monitoring of Human Rights Violations

Delegates may also consider creating an international monitoring mechanism to document abuses against civilians. Independent observers could investigate reports of killings, forced displacement, and destruction of property. Their findings could be reported to the United Nations and the international community. Public reporting would increase accountability. It could also discourage armed groups from targeting civilians. Although monitoring alone cannot stop violence, it helps establish factual records and increases pressure for compliance with international humanitarian law.

4. Evaluation

The Cyprus Crisis demonstrates how ethnic tensions, international alliances, and foreign intervention can combine to produce long-term humanitarian consequences. Between 1963 and 1974, thousands of civilians were killed, injured, or displaced. Entire communities were forced to abandon their homes. The conflict ultimately divided the island into separate political regions that remain in place today (Ker-Lindsay).

International efforts attempted to manage the crisis. United Nations peacekeeping forces helped reduce violence and prevented the conflict from expanding into a larger war between Greece and Turkey. However, peacekeeping alone could not resolve the political disputes between the communities or the interests of external powers (United Nations Peacekeeping).

Delegates must therefore consider both immediate and long-term challenges. Protecting civilians during active conflict is essential. At the same time, policies must avoid escalating tensions or strengthening divisions between communities. Effective solutions require cooperation, careful diplomacy, and respect for international humanitarian law.

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